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THE SELF IN SELF-INTEREST: LAND, LABOUR AND TEMPORALITIES IN MALAWI'S AGRARIAN CHANGE

Harri Englund

In the southern margin of Dedza District in Malawi's Central Region (see map opposite), the site of over two years of fieldwork in 1992–93 and 1996–97, communal work parties appear to be on the decline. In contrast, smaller-scale labour contracts, known as 'piecework' (*ganyu* in Chichewa) and invariably entailing a reward in cash or in kind, are the most common means by which 'extra-domestic' assistance is recruited in agriculture. The main queries of this study are twofold. On the one hand, is this reliance on small-scale labour contracts an index of agrarian change? On the other, what can the study of personhood contribute to our understanding of agrarian change?

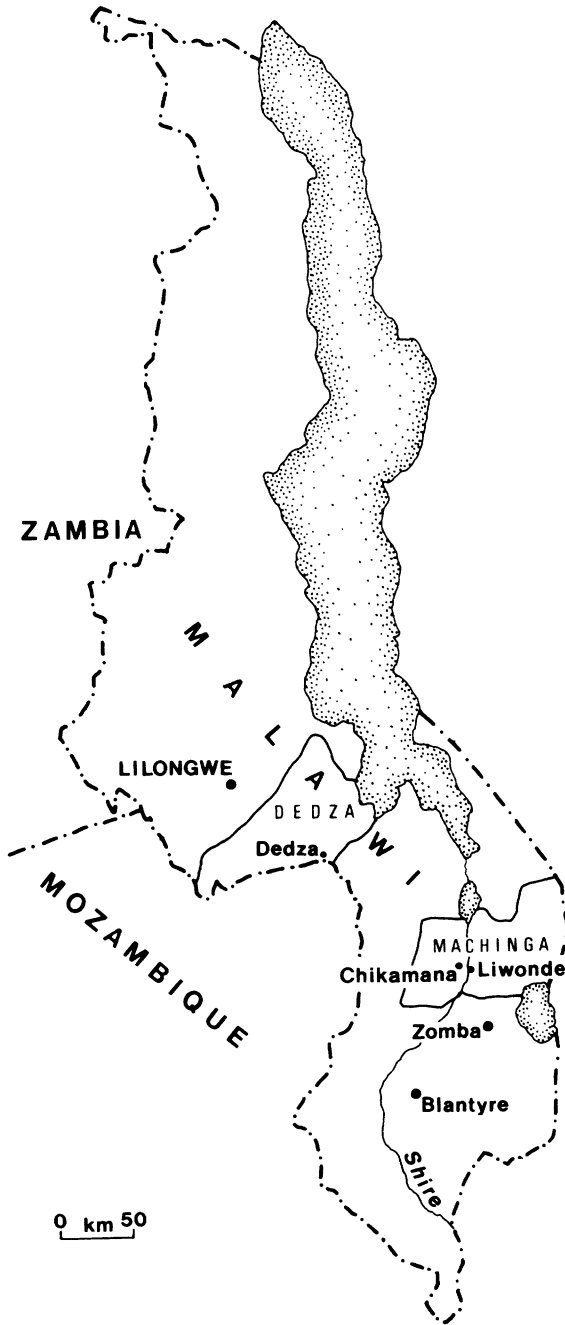
These queries arise from an unsettling fact, already noted by Pottier (1988) in his study of a former labour-migrant community in Zambia. Pottier described a decline in customary work parties and a definite turn to paid agricultural work (1988: 84–6). However, 'the bulk of the labour . . . [was] still borne by small groups of women who [were] related through kinship or affinity' (1988: 85). A somewhat similar observation about kinship and affinity in paid agricultural work can be made of Chewa and Ngoni villagers in Dedza District. By highlighting this observation I attempt to go beyond Pottier's conclusion that social relations have become 'dyadic' (1988: 83)—contractual and individualised.

The responses to the above queries cannot sustain a notion of unequivocal 'change' in local agriculture and sociality. There are several different temporalities which constitute the social and economic world of Dedza villagers. The challenge is to understand their variable dynamics and interplay, and to resist the facile juxtaposition of 'change' and 'continuity', including the unhelpful composite 'change-and-continuity'.

I argue that big work parties have long been an exceptional mode of labour recruitment, arising from very specific needs, and that the labour performed by the relatively small household units represents an institution of the *longue durée*. I show how, under such particularism, the *ganyu* labour arrangements are integral to the constitution of economic actors as moral persons.

The argument is somewhat counter-intuitive, because the use of money comes deceptively close to the 'commodification' of labour. But, if money is taken to be an index of change, analysis may merely indicate a peculiarly 'Western' habit of imputing definite moral qualities to it (cf. Parry and Bloch, 1989; Guyer, 1995). According to such a viewpoint, monetary transactions are 'disembedded' from the fabric of social obligations and privileges.

Among some students of agricultural labour contracts, such a tacit assumption has led to a teleological view of agrarian change. Scott, for



Malawi, showing the field sites of Peter Probst's research at Chikamana and of Harri Englund's in Dedza.

example, has claimed that wealthy South East Asian peasants are 'in an ideological vacuum' (1985: 184). Their quest for accumulation appears to make customary obligations obsolete. However, the continuing need for casual labour means that they are '*not yet* able to dispense entirely with the precapitalist normative context of village life' (1985: 185, emphasis added).

A teleological view of agrarian change represents an 'ideological vacuum' as a liminal condition on the path towards complete disembeddedness. Social and economic change is, in such a perspective, a shift from one system of values to another. In the study of labour contracts, this shift is disclosed by juxtaposing an 'old' style of labour recruitment with a 'new' style, and by calling the discrepancy between the styles 'change', often associated with gender or generational conflicts (see e.g. den Ouden, 1995).

The analytical procedure bypasses several issues of both theoretical and political import. It assumes a coherence of value which must be probed. It identifies change with globalised forms, such as monetary transactions, and fails to appreciate the variable historical conditions under which 'change' occurs. The 'input' of new cash crops, for example, is too easily seen to produce the 'output' of changing social relations. This study argues for an analysis of temporalities, personhood and incoherent value systems. Knowledge about changing livelihoods does not, as such, warrant claims about changing sociality.¹

Recent anthropological perspectives on money and property relations have persuasively deployed a distinction between short-term and long-term transactional cycles (Parry and Bloch, 1989; Hann, 1998). The distinction has the merit of identifying variable contexts, some allowing relatively anonymous transactions, others persisting through obvious changes by fostering critical moral and cosmological realities. The perspective is suitably broad to encourage innovative ethnographic and historical research, but increased analytical rigour can prevent spurious propositions. One is the domain of the 'economy', as if production, distribution and consumption could be distinguished from the *reproduction* of subjects.

The allusion to bodily procreation is deliberate (cf. Weiner, 1980; Strathern, 1998: 226–9). What conventional economic analysis regards as 'material resources' make a vital contribution to the very making of persons and households. Animals among pastoralists (Broch-Due, 1993) and land among cultivators (Shipton, 1994) can be integral to transformations in the life cycle—not as 'signs' or 'extensions' of those transformations but as the means of their realisation.

The notion of reproduction itself can inspire spurious propositions if its own historicity is not appreciated. A key starting point is, as mentioned, a sense of different temporalities in Dedza villagers' social and economic

¹ For fresh perspectives on agrarian change in Africa see the case studies of Berry (1993), Moore and Vaughan (1994) and Guyer (1997). More specifically on 'division of labour' in Africa's agrarian change see e.g. Guyer (1988, 1992), Francis (1995) and Geschiere (1995). My analysis is in broad agreement with these excellent studies. My explicit focus on personhood draws, however, upon partly different ethnographic and theoretical resources. It is the task of analysis to show their contribution to the study of agrarian change.

world. The economic fortunes of the area have witnessed many changes during this century, from the Portuguese 'shopkeeper colonialism' (Hanlon, 1984: 15) and labour migration to the current reliance on smallholder agriculture and petty trading. I discuss these changes below. But such changes, if significant, indicate a temporality that is distinct from the historicity of the *longue durée*. Towards the end of this study, strangers and gender relations provide perspectives on this ultimate question about agrarian change in Dedza villages: what are the historical conditions of personhood and the morality its reproduction fosters?

Another spurious proposition would regard 'reproduction' as synonymous with normative consensus and the coherence of value. The challenge is, however, to understand how conflicts emerge in the process of reproduction. One approach would suggest that conflicts emerge when, in the recruitment of *ganyu* labour, self-interested actors pursue mutually incompatible objectives. Yet it is the origin and content of their interests that must be explored. A notion of persons as the subject of their own interests is not supported by ethnography from Dedza villages. The self appears as a composite of relationships, both in Dedza villagers' moral discourses and in the analyst's appreciation of their emergent interests. Conflicts of interest are, therefore, internal to the person not the result of mutually independent subjects pursuing their 'own' objectives.

RELATIONSHIPS THAT PULL THE PERSON APART

I begin with a brief example of the dilemmas involved in recruiting labour through *ganyu* piecework arrangements. John is a Mozambican who married in a village in Dedza District in 1969. He has been able to achieve a measure of affluence through his successful years as a labour migrant in South Africa and through the diligent cultivation of vegetables, the main source of cash in the area after the end of labour migration. All his land belongs to the family of his Malawian wife, who died in 1984. John soon remarried in a nearby Malawian village, but he took his new wife to live with him and his children in his spacious house in the first wife's village. They also continued to cultivate the first wife's gardens.

In his recruitment of *ganyu* labour John consistently favoured his first wife's relatives at the expense of the second wife's family, thereby revealing the different value of the two sets of affinity. By favouring the first wife's relatives, John seemed to act in line with the relationships which still constituted him as a son- and brother-in-law entitled to village membership and land.

This favouritism did not pass unnoticed in the second wife's village, and John's desire to return to Mozambique in 1993 brought tension into the open. The second wife's guardian (*nkhoswe*) sent him a letter announcing that he would not be allowed to take his wife to Mozambique. John hardly ever even visited his wife's village and ignored her demands for assistance for her relatives. In his first wife's village, on the other hand, John was widely respected not only by his affines but also by many fellow villagers. His house was a frequent venue for beer parties. Moreover, when the war in Mozambique brought his relatives to his neighbourhood in 1986 as refugees

he supported them singlehanded for months before relief aid commenced in the area.

By selecting his first wife's relatives for *ganyu* John thus refused to view the end of a conjugal bond as the end of affinity. This affinity, despite his marriage to another woman, ensured that he could continue to live and cultivate in the first wife's village. It was the plan to return with his relatives to Mozambique in 1993 that revealed the limits of John's capacity to realise his interests. The return would have entailed the end of his marriage.

John's example indicates basic aspects of personhood among Dedza villagers. His material prosperity was predicated on his entitlement to land through affinity in his first wife's village. Other sets of relationships—his displaced relatives, for example—prompted new interests, such as the desire to return to Mozambique. Yet another set of relationships—affinity through the second wife—hindered the realisation of those interests. Such complexities of personhood must belong, in this context, to the analysis of agrarian change. The task for the next section is to outline the conceptual apparatus of this perspective. Ideas of the self and interest must be explored both in scholarly literature and in Dedza villagers' own notions.

IDEAS OF SELF-INTEREST

Philosophical analyses usually understand by 'self-interest' a theory of rationality (see Parfit, 1984: 3–51). The challenge, in understanding agrarian change, is to go beyond the theories of self-interest *and* their critique—even the critique starts from the premise that the acting subject is a unitary self.² The anthropological perspectives on personhood which represent the self as a composite or 'fractal' (see e.g. Riesman, 1986; Wagner, 1992) imply a different view of action. The person who acts in line with his or her constitutive relationships does not actually *cause* his or her actions. Nor are persons the 'original proprietors of their selves' (Strathern, 1988: 135), as the self-interest theories seem to assume. To act is to disclose the contributions others have earlier performed on oneself (Mosko, 1992: 702). Acts and events make constitutive relationships visible, not by the simple logic of reciprocity, but sometimes by painstakingly eliciting relatedness.

At this juncture a distinction must be drawn between the composite self as an analytical notion, challenging the individualistic notions of subjectivities, and the composite self as a moral sentiment. Both notions enhance our understanding of agricultural labour in Dedza District, but they must not be conflated. The latter discloses aspects of Dedza villagers' morality, the nature of legitimate interests as villagers themselves see them. But, because the origin of interests is never reducible to expressed meanings, the anthropologist needs an *analytical* notion of the composite self that extends beyond the purview of particular persons. This notion probes the field of

² On the one hand, the idea of a collectivity—'we' instead of 'I'—acting in a self-interested manner merely transforms the scale of unitary subjects (cf. Williams, 1985: 15). On the other, even if it is assumed that a person's love for certain other persons affects what is in his or her interest, the acting subject remains ontologically prior to social relationships (cf. Williams, 1985: 81; Parfit, 1984: 5–6; Frank, 1990).

relationships which impinges on a person's interests. It views relationships as sources of contingency that undermine persons' control over their interests.³

A perspective which stresses relatedness always seems to have difficulty in identifying particularities. And yet, as mentioned, Dedza villagers themselves appear to regard the households of parents and their children (sg. *banja*; also one of the terms for 'family') as the primary units of local agriculture. Such particularism amid a flow of relatedness is, in effect, a veritable achievement.

Households are the primary units not only for material production but also for becoming *persons*. The 'socialisation' of children is not at issue, as if they embodied pre-social being awaiting incorporation into society. Children stand at the interface of the various relationships and substances that constitute households themselves. As such, an examination of procreation offers a perspective which qualifies the apparent particularism of households.⁴ It shows that, just as reproduction is not confined to households, households are not 'basic' units for the reproduction of 'larger' social orders (cf. Moore, 1994: 89).

Dedza villagers' notion of conception attributes equal significance to maternal and paternal substances. Conception is a result of the maternal blood and the paternal 'blood agreeing with each other' (*magazi ogwirizana*). Only one man is thought to be responsible for pregnancy, as is also reflected in the idea that disastrous consequences can follow if the woman has sexual intercourse with another man during her pregnancy. If their blood does not agree the foetus can die or she herself becomes seriously ill.

The parents refrain from intercourse for about four months after the birth, and the period ends with a rite where the mother holds the child firmly during intercourse. 'Placing the child' (variously spoken of as *kuika* or *kulongosola* or *kutenga mwana*) is said to 'warm the child up' (*kutenthetsa mwana*). It introduces the child to this-worldly realities where the living are 'hot' (*otentha*) and where a 'cold' (*wozizira*) child risks being overpowered by others. Although the hot-cold contrast underlies many other transitions in the life cycle, it assumes special significance during pregnancy and childbirth, giving rise to a complex of afflictions known as *mdulo*.

These precautions and rites indicate the interdependence of parents and their offspring, not least the father's contribution to the child's well-being. The father's recognised role extends to the child's 'clan name' (*mfunda*). It invariably derives from the man who is thought to have conceived the child, whether or not he is the mother's husband.⁵

³ On the problem of 'knowledgeable subjects' in agrarian change see Gould (1997: 72-3).

⁴ On conceptualising households in Africa see Guyer and Peters (1987).

⁵ The observations that Mair (1951: 103) and Barnes (1959: 226) made long ago about 'clans' and the use of the *mfunda* name are still valid. In Barnes's words, 'there are no clan heads, no clan exogamy, no clan taboos, no beliefs in a common origin from a legendary ancestor, no clan totems, and no correlation between clan and territory' (1959: 226). *Mfunda* associates the person with a wide field of agnatic ties, social groupings which are more situational than corporate.

The actual development of the foetus, however, depends on the mother, particularly on her consumption of *nsima*, the porridge-like staple made of maize. A young mother is advised by elderly women to eat as much *nsima* as she can, because it gives 'strength' (*nyonga*) and makes the foetus 'grow' (*kukula*). In other words, the development of the foetus into a child and a person does not follow by itself from the fact of conception. It takes effort and the capacity of *nsima* and many other uses of maize to promote growth and well-being is a recurring theme throughout the life cycle.

It is usually maize from the mother's own garden that provides the indispensable *nsima*. Here another set of relationships contributes to the household's reproductive work, because the mother has land only by virtue of specific relationships. The 'matrilineal' features of Dedza villagers' social life include the practice whereby women are the most visible custodians of land. Marriages, moreover, are usually uxori-local. But, as in other 'matrilineal systems', access to agricultural land is not best imagined in terms of women's 'control' over land. The sibling tie between uterine sisters and brothers is expected to remain strong despite uxori-local marriages. A brother or a mother's brother acts as his sisters' and their children's guardian (*nkhoswe*) in litigation and in the formal distribution of land. Hence the maize that makes a woman's foetus grow is itself the product of specific relationships that underlie her access to land. Maize appears as another substance which carries further the contribution of the father's 'blood'.

More precisely, maize is gendered wealth which both separates women from men and blurs the very distinction. On the one hand, maize cultivation is largely in the hands of women, who also prepare all *nsima*. Maize and maize products are the most usual gifts in various contexts, always given and received by women. This gendered pattern extends to the built space, where every adult woman has exclusive access to at least one granary (*nkhokwe*). The granary is an important sign of a woman's adulthood and as such surpasses even marriage, because a woman may get a granary as soon as she is given her own garden. A man, by contrast, finds that the maize from his garden, if he has one, is put into the granary of his mother-in-law until his wife is given her own garden. As long as a house is without a granary it is not recognised as a separate household. It belongs to the household from whose granary its occupants are fed.

On the other hand, every person, regardless of gender, owes his or her 'growth' in part to the gendered wealth of maize, making the male-female distinction much less clear. Seen from another perspective, however, the association of women with maize is a further example of how particularism presupposes relatedness. The multiple flows and contributions that carry the person from conception to adulthood are only apparently concealed by the close association of women with maize. It is the task of every new person and every new harvest that follows from the household's reproductive work eventually to engage in disclosing the household's constitutive relationships. Apart from *ganyu* labour arrangements, life crises and less dramatic daily tasks elicit contributions of assistance and gifts between apparently distinct households.

The difficulty in Vaughan's (1983) interpretation of women's exclusive possession of granaries illuminates this perspective further. For Vaughan,

exclusive possession indicated an ideal of household self-sufficiency. Her problem of 'unconscious co-operation' (1983: 278) arose from the sharing of food between women who, despite the fieldworker's observations, did not think that any sharing was taking place at all.

Vaughan's notion of 'unconscious co-operation' derived, in effect, from a problematic notion of 'self-sufficiency'. There is no obvious reason why exclusive possession of granaries should indicate a quest for setting households apart from one another as 'independent' economic units. If each such possession is a corollary of the person's position in the life cycle, reproductive capacities are at issue. Exclusive possession does not *exclude* a person or a household but, on the contrary, enables that person or household to *participate* in full moral agency. Particularism is both an outgrowth of relatedness and a standpoint to make relationships visible.

Whether they are persons or households, composite particularities are also explicit themes in Dedza villagers' moral discourses. There are few traces of altruism in these discourses, such as in the salient idioms of 'love' (*chikondi*) and 'care' (*chisamalo*). The village headman, for example, is expected to evince *chikondi* in order to secure his subjects' respect and obedience. Love is a corollary of his position, not a sign of blind altruism.⁶

More generally, people perform solicitous acts for others in anticipation of the performance by which these others must reveal *their* constitutive relationships. This is put succinctly by the proverb *kupatsa ndiko kuika*, literally 'to give is to place'. It is usually offered as a response when a person is confronted with criticism by, for example, his or her spouse for the generosity which this person showed towards a third person. The response points out that generosity does not mean throwing things away. It 'places' the thing in the recipient's memory so that when the recipient has objects of value they will return to the original giver.

'Care' (*chisamalo*), like *chikondi*, is an idiom that properly describes and evaluates kin relationships (*ubale*), but *chisamalo* is more rarely used in reference to relationships outside this domain. *Chisamalo* most often denotes the effort that is involved in raising and managing a family. Both the matrilocally recruited guardian (*nkhoswe*) and the father are expected to 'care' for the offspring whom their sisters or sisters' daughters and wife, respectively, 'have borne them' (*anawabalira*). *Chisamalo* is, of course, also used to assess the performance of mothers themselves. An important implication is that the mother or the father who 'does not care' (*sasamala*) can be disowned by her or his children. Parents, in turn, are thought to be able to disown a child, especially if the child has been discovered to be a witch. In the past the mother's curse (see e.g. Mitchell, 1956: 135; Marwick, 1965: 164-5) was a particularly dramatic inversion of parental care, but Dedza villagers deny that it is still practised in their area.

⁶ It must be stressed that the focus in this paragraph is on discourse, not on the various ways in which colonial and post-colonial regimes have, in Mamdani's phrase, inflated chiefs' and headmen's authority into 'a clenched fist' (1996: 23).

These brief observations indicate 'cultural meanings' which come remarkably close to the notion of the composite self. Persons and households appear as the outcomes of others' contributions and are, in turn, morally obliged to act in line with those relationships. However, such meanings do not resolve the analytical problems of self-interest and labour arrangements. The reason is not simply the possibility that these meanings merely obscure 'the naked exercise of power' (Hyden and Williams, 1994: 71) in a 'moral economy' which, according to Bourdieu, 'is forced to devote as much time to concealing the reality of economic acts as it expends in carrying them out' (1977: 172). As mentioned, Dedza villagers acknowledge the reality of interested action and appear unaware of altruism.

The analytical problems of self-interest and labour arrangements require an *analytical* notion of the composite self. It is a tool with which to discern the origin of interests in a multitude of acts and contingencies, none of which is reducible to any one actor. The notion avoids, therefore, the fallacy of culturalism, which finds the sources of value in expressed meanings and is thereby unable to account for normative dissonance in the same community. Lack of control characterises the moral economic process: lack of control over the meaning of particular acts, and over the interests that emerge as those acts unfold.

The analytical notion of the composite self undermines culturalism, not the reality, and force, of moral sentiments. Even though the emergence of interests is not reducible to culturally specific moral sentiments, interests are expressed in terms of those moral sentiments. It is important, therefore, to specify the historical conditions which are compatible with the moral notion of the composite self. However different its temporality is from the ephemeral changes of economic fortunes, a moral sentiment also belongs to history.

CHANGES IN LIVELIHOODS

The southern margin of Dedza District lies in the immediate vicinity of the Angónia District of Mozambique. Villages are large and compact, and their gardens are, in some cases, several miles away. The garden land is mainly rich red loam, although clay and sandy soils are also common in parts of the Malawian side of the border. The altitude in this highland area is around 5,500 ft, and the rains are often plentiful. The basic distinction in agricultural land is between *mindá* (sg. *munda*) and *madimba* (sg. *dimba*) gardens. The former are dependent on rainfall and are the land where most maize cultivation takes place. Apart from maize (*chimanga*), beans (*nyemba*), pumpkins (*maungu*) and millet (*mawere*) are also commonly planted in *mindá*. *Madimba* are situated near streams or wells and are cultivated especially during the dry season. Here takes place most of the vegetable and potato cultivation which now represents the principal source of cash in the area.

The main tool in agriculture is the hoe; no villager in the area has access to a plough. Very few have cattle; nearly 40 per cent of my sample households in 1992 had no livestock at all. Dedza villagers assert that all agricultural tasks can be performed equally well by women or men. In practice, as

mentioned, cultivation in *minda* gardens, especially weeding, tends to be women's work, whereas men often take responsibility for the cultivation of *madimba*.⁷ The extent to which this pattern is reflected in the pooling of cash income within households varies greatly. The brewing of *masese* beer and *kachasu* liquor for sale is, in any case, a women's prerogative.

Dedza villagers perceive acute deterioration in their economy, contrasting the poverty of small-scale vegetable cultivation with the times of plenty. Two major transformations have contributed to this perception. On the one hand, Angónia District in Mozambique attracted Portuguese shopkeepers and farmers in the 1950s, after the Salazar government in Portugal had banned forced labour and ended the leases of the huge land concessions known as *prazo* (Newitt, 1995: 448–51). The *prazo* concessions had never disrupted the patterns of land acquisition in the Angónia borderland, the area assuming the role of a labour reserve for plantations elsewhere.

The Portuguese entrepreneurs who arrived in the 1950s purchased local produce for urban markets in Mozambique and Malawi, introduced new breeds of vegetables and used pesticides and chemical fertilisers extensively in *madimba* gardens. In order to secure access to local produce they engaged in patronage with villagers on both sides of the border. 'There was never hunger' (*kunalibe njala*), runs a common assessment among villagers in Dedza and Angónia, conveying dismay at the exodus of the Portuguese upon Mozambique's independence in 1975 (for more discussion see Englund, 1996a).

On the other hand, an even more profound transformation has been the end of labour migration to South Africa. Labour migration has deep roots in the area, beginning in the last century and reaching stupendous proportions after 1930 (Crush *et al.*, 1991; Borges Coelho, 1993). Dedza became a major recruitment centre for the Witwatersrand Native Labour Association. Virtually every man born before the 1960s has at some point worked in the mines, plantations or towns of South Africa, Zimbabwe or Zambia.

Labour migration came to an abrupt end in the mid-1970s, when the Malawian and the Mozambican governments both imposed severe restrictions on the international mobility of their rural populace. The Frelimo government had, among others, ideological reasons to oppose its subjects' migration to South Africa and Rhodesia, whereas the Malawi government was becoming concerned about the labour shortages on domestic plantations (see Kydd and Christiansen, 1982; Chirwa, 1996). The 1970s witnessed a massive return of men from South Africa. Currently labour migration, along with the Portuguese entrepreneurs, is a major source of nostalgia in the area.

It is evident that, before these transformations, more cash circulated in Dedza villages than now. Spacious iron-roofed houses, now partly corroded, attest to the wealth that was. Monochrome photographs, taken in South

⁷ This contrasts with the finding of Hirschmann and Vaughan, over a decade ago in southern Malawi, that *madimba* are 'women's gardens' (1983: 94). As is discussed below, the importance of *madimba* cultivation, and men's position in it, must be seen in the context of diminishing opportunities for labour migration and other formal means of securing income.

African studios, of young men in smart suits, and the women's well-worn dresses, bought in South Africa or from the Portuguese shops, are painful reminders of a standard of living which now appears denied to villagers.

During President Kamuzu Banda's regime the adoption of maize as a cash crop was effectively discouraged by the low producer prices offered at the Agricultural Development and Marketing Corporation (Admarc). In 1992, for example, two bags of maize sold at Admarc produced just over fifty kwacha, whereas the same amount of maize used as malt (*chimera*) for brewing beer could produce as much as 200 kwacha. Whatever capital there may have been in southern Dedza villages in the 1970s, it was not invested in such cash crops as coffee or tobacco. Some young, mainly unmarried, men move to work on the estates elsewhere in Malawi, but their annual income is often lower than what can be obtained from vegetable cultivation.⁸

Banda's autocratic regime was ousted in the 1994 multi-party elections, where Bakili Muluzi became the new state President and his United Democratic Front (UDF) the new ruling party. Few villagers in southern Dedza have seen any improvement in their economic condition since the elections. The new government assumed power on a neo-liberal platform whose most dramatic consequences for Dedza villagers have been the removal of subsidies on chemical fertilisers, inflation and lack of credit for local enterprises. A new market place in the area came to symbolise not only the new government's commitment to a 'free' economy but also smallholders' difficulties in the neoliberal environment. Itinerant traders have taken over much of the market, and villagers' foodstuffs, particularly tomatoes, often overwhelm it, enabling middlemen from towns to pay prices which rarely yield enough even for another cycle of fertilisers and pesticides.⁹

THE PROBLEM OF CHANGE

This predicament of impoverishment, percolating through villages, is one context for examining change and economic interests in Dedza District. How does the lack of cash and capital transform the interests which underlie Dedza villagers' engagement in their economy? In their nostalgia, villagers do not so much juxtapose past and present systems of value as underscore contrasting economic opportunities. The desire for commercial success and prosperity is a taken-for-granted disposition, not the antithesis of a valued 'tradition' (see Englund, 1996b). Elderly villagers do relate stories, heard

⁸ In late 1992 US\$1.00 was approximately equal to four kwacha. In late 1996 US\$1.00 was approximately fifteen kwacha.

⁹ By 1998 the UDF government had begun to realise some of the consequences of its neo-liberal economic policies. Excessive rain in many parts of the country created food shortages which were readily exploited by private traders. They emptied Admarc of its maize and sold it on at a profit until it was announced that Admarc would sell only 30 kg of maize to each customer. In 1998 the government announced that it would establish a competition secretariat to regulate free trade, because overcharging, price fixing and collusion were rapidly undermining the 'freedom' of economy.

from their grandparents, about whole villages eating together in communal acts of consumption. Yet such stories indicate, for elderly villagers themselves, more the smallness of villages, associated with constant warfare, than an ideal mode of social life.

Dedza villagers' moral discourses on enrichment and material welfare portray individualism as an unacceptable disposition, most forcefully conveyed by the image of the witch. It is important to stress two qualifications, however. First, material prosperity is not equated with individualism in any incontestable manner; the 'rich' and the 'poor' can both evince individualism. Second, the converse of individualism is not the communal sharing of resources and work.

The problem of change revolves around an *historical* observation—'extra-domestic' collaborative forms of labour have long been rare in Malawi. In his extensive account of the agrarian history of southern Malawi, Mandala (1990) has consistently represented the households of parents, children and, in some cases, grandchildren as the units which perform the bulk of agricultural labour. During the hundred years covered by Mandala's analysis collaborative forms of labour have appeared, in the main, as concomitants of exploitation. For example, the *thangata* system forced tenants to provide rent labour for their European and Asian landlords (Mandala, 1990 121–2; cf. Kandwire, 1979). Mandala (e.g. 1990: 140) also pays special attention to the institutions that mobilised children and youths to work for adults. Voluntary collaboration between different households, by contrast, appears exceptional in this historical survey.

Mandala's observations on household labour in colonial southern Malawi are remarkably consistent even with *central* Malawian *pre-colonial* history (see Phiri, 1984: 15). Davison (1993) and Peters (1997), in turn, discuss this striking continuity in the contemporary context of women's increasing labour burden in rural Malawi. Despite the pressures brought by commodification, decreasing farm sizes and men's continuing labour migration to Malawian towns, women shun collaboration in production.

From its autocratic past to its neo-liberal present, post-colonial Malawi has provided a permissive ideological context for such particularism. The 'humanist' and 'socialist' experiments in Zambia and Mozambique, for example, never impressed Banda's regime. In Dedza District farmers' clubs were promoted by Banda's regime, and much less actively by the UDF government, as the only institutions which brought different smallholder households together. Their main task was the provision of chemical fertilisers on credit. Apart from the club fields where different methods and crop varieties were demonstrated, the clubs never entailed collaboration in production.¹⁰

¹⁰ President Muluzi and the UDF government have frequently appealed for 'self-help' in rural development. The Malawi Social Action Fund (Masaf) was established to provide local communities with material resources if they in turn provided labour to develop their facilities, especially local schools. Such communal modes of 'self-help' have not extended to agriculture.

GANYU LABOUR: PARTICULARISM AND RELATEDNESS

The task of this section is to compare big work parties and *ganyu* labour arrangements and to provide an understanding of the persistence of particularist production in changing economic circumstances. The observations above on the simultaneous reproduction of persons and households help to situate this particularist production in its relational context. To better appreciate the specific temporality of household reproduction, the next section discusses the conditions under which *ganyu* arrangements threaten to become exploitation.

Work parties are known as *moŵa wa udzu*, 'beer for grass', and, as the name suggests, beer and the non-alcoholic drink *thobwa* are the most common compensation for work, not cash or, usually, even food. The organiser announces the work party at a gathering of several people, such as a beer party, a court meeting or a funeral, and anyone is permitted to participate in the work. Work parties are usually arranged when a great amount of monotonous work has to be performed rapidly, typically cutting grass for thatching houses. Work parties are rarer in agriculture, although they may be organised for weeding and harvesting. Overall, work parties of all kinds are extremely rare, and during fieldwork in 1992–93 and 1996–97 I witnessed only five work parties, all held by different households. This rare incidence also accounts for the fact that there is little expectation of reciprocity, the consumption of beer ending the transaction.

Although the ability to brew beer for free consumption in a work party also indicates relative affluence, wealthy villagers usually prefer *ganyu* labour. *Ganyu* refers to all kinds of piecework, not only to agricultural work. *Ganyu* labourers are selected by the recruiter himself or herself, and their tasks need not lead to another period of work. The reward is cash or in kind, usually paid after the work has been completed. Relatives and affines tend to be recruited especially in agriculture, whereas other tasks, such as in construction or herding, seem to imply less moral pressure to find labour from specific social categories. Because most marriages are formed within a five-mile radius, it is not uncommon to find the husband's relatives performing agricultural *ganyu* although the wife's relatives predominate. There is no evidence that relatives are paid less than non-relatives; indeed, as is discussed in the next section, strangers are usually paid the least. Youths, on the other hand, receive smaller payments than adults for the same work.

Income from formal employment and anticipated discrepancies in harvests between different households often occasion expectations of, and opportunities for, *ganyu* arrangements. Supplementary harvests in Mozambique, where land is less scarce than on the Malawian side of the border, are one reason for such discrepancies. I recorded cases of households which had better harvests than others in their uxori-local neighbourhoods, because the men were Mozambicans with land in their villages of origin. In such cases it was common for the wife's sisters and mother to provide *ganyu* labour at some point during the agricultural cycle. Migrants to towns, on the other hand, often maintain their land in villages by employing relatives and affines to perform *ganyu*. The wealthiest migrants rent land in towns and have little

need of maize from their villages. Much of it can be consumed by their *ganyu* labour.

The numbers of *ganyu* labour at any given time range from one to half a dozen, and no kin or affinal category is specifically excluded from *ganyu* arrangements. However, children and grandchildren are recruited, acting as recruiters only when they have established their own households. *Ganyu* labour in agriculture thus presupposes distinct households in order to make relationships visible.

Unlike in big work parties, therefore, the recruiter is able to determine the exact composition of labour. The interests involved in selecting *ganyu* labour can be understood only within the wider context of relationships which constitute persons as composite selves. wealthy and prominent persons come under pressure to use their position for the benefit of their relatives. On the other hand, the very prominence of party branch leaders, headmen and councillors, migrants to towns, grocery shopkeepers and other entrepreneurs is measured by the extent to which they can make others work for them. In similar vein, the reason why the deceased person is called a 'chief' (*mfumu*) before his or her burial is the fact that the whole village is expected to stop all other work other than the conduct of the funeral requires. The capacity to make others work likens the deceased to the chief, the prototypical 'big man'.

It is crucial to appreciate the actual content of a *ganyu* recruiter's interest. As Mauss (1966: 46) observed long ago, material wealth and social relations appear contradictory in a world view which centres on a cleavage between interest and disinterestedness. Against that, Dedza villagers' dilemma does not focus on an obligation to 'share' wealth with others. *Ganyu* recruiters are self-interested actors whose concern is to protect, and possibly increase, personal wealth.¹¹ Yet wealth (*chuma*) becomes wealth only when it mobilises others, e.g. for *ganyu* labour. Wealth which is individual and private, mobilising no one but the person him- or herself, constitutes its proprietor as the inversion of moral being, a witch.

Put in the terms introduced earlier, Dedza villagers' dilemma highlights problems in the disclosure of the composite self. The imagery of 'sharing' does not convey the process, because the *ganyu* recruiter could 'share' wealth only if its source was in the recruiter as a private proprietor. In agriculture, the recruitment of *ganyu* labour makes visible some of the relationships which constitute the recruiter as a person, or as a household, entitled to land. The dilemma arises because such disclosure can be only partial. The number of potential *ganyu* labourers always exceeds the quantity of rewards that can be paid to them. Who gets mobilised is therefore a question which engages the recruiter in the micro-politics of everyday life.

¹¹ The recruitment of *ganyu* labour can, of course, indicate a desire to intensify agricultural production. More often, however, *ganyu* labour is wanted, because it eases the burden of agricultural work. In any case, the intensification of cultivation through *ganyu* is not incompatible with the notion of self-interest discussed here.

Equally important is the fact that *ganyu* labourers themselves disclose their constitutive relationships by working for their recruiter. The anticipated reward indicates the moral force of deliberate *effort*, already noted above in the idioms of *chikondi* and *chisamalo* and in women's nourishing work during their pregnancies. As mentioned, it is not merely wealthy labour recruiters who face the danger of being accused of witchcraft. Their poor relatives, if seen to be passive recipients of others' wealth, are no less likely to be accused.

The fact that disclosure can be only partial also accounts for the lack of control over interests. Attention to certain relationships can mean neglect of others, giving rise to conflict which, in turn, can reconfigure the shape of a person's interests. The example of John, above, highlights some aspects of these processes. From one perspective John's conduct upheld the moral notion of the composite self because he disclosed his constitutive relationships by recruiting his deceased wife's relatives to perform *ganyu*. From another perspective, his neglect of the second wife's relatives called his morality into question. John's lack of control over the meaning of his acts considerably hindered the return to Mozambique which he so desired. Here the *analytical* notion of the composite self reveals its force. The notion is indispensable for tracing the sources of normative dissonance amid a generalised moral sentiment.

This discussion of *ganyu* labour helps us to appreciate the inadequacy of 'contractual' and 'individualised' as descriptive labels for such labour arrangements. Among Dedza villagers the bulk of 'extra-domestic' agricultural labour is based not on contracts between mutually independent individuals but on the disclosure of composite selves. The apparent particularism of household (re)production is therefore merely a standpoint for making relationships visible. Its temporality is distinct from changes in economic fortunes. Far from being an index of social change, the particularism of (re)production belongs to a long-term pattern of moral being.

STRANGERS, ALIENATION AND GENDER

The above analysis has already indicated how villagers in Dedza District have long participated in a market economy that extends beyond the confines of mere subsistence. They have provided labour for mines and plantations elsewhere in southern Africa, and they have worked for Portuguese settlers. Nor is the commodification of labour alien to their 'local' economy. In this regard, the persistence of non-market principles in households' agricultural labour arrangements stands out as an achievement.¹²

¹² My focus on the *longue durée* highlights the interdependence of particularism and relatedness in household production and reproduction. *Ganyu* labour arrangements are one possible, albeit not necessary, example of this phenomenon. It may well be that *ganyu*, with its monetary transactions, has gained such importance only in recent times precisely because it discloses how land and labour are *not* commodities in certain contexts.

This analysis of self-interest and agricultural labour must also ask the ultimate question about change by attending to the historical conditions of the composite self. I use the term 'alienation' to denote those conditions that are antithetical to the composite self. The concept is notoriously vague, but hardly more so than one of its opposites—'embeddedness', still an occasional component of the scholarly vocabulary (see e.g. Bassett, 1993; Hann, 1998). 'Alienation' was a concept integral to Marx's philosophy of internal relations (see Ollman, 1971). It referred to the processes by which constitutive relations were obscured and the ideas of mutual independence fostered. Applied in a specific ethnographic case, the concept does not need to carry additional assumptions about 'human nature' in order to perform this basic analytical task.¹³

In the history of southern Dedza District the conditions for alienation were laid down when the Portuguese settlers established their farms. As mentioned, however, little actual alienation took place, because the Portuguese entered into relations with villagers. A far more critical process of alienation was introduced by the presence of thousands of 'self-settled' Mozambican refugees in Dedza villages between 1986 and 1993. The plight of those refugees who were landless and lacked ties with the area shows how, under specific conditions, agricultural *ganyu* can assume the properties of exploitation. In this section I also discuss the most obvious recent change in local agriculture—the increasing importance of *madimba* gardens as a source of income, especially the implications for gender relations.

The majority of refugees in the villages of southern Dedza were from the immediate frontier area. Many were able to cultivate at least part of their land throughout the displacement, crossing the border almost daily. These refugees had little need to find paid work in Malawi. Some earned cash by selling items of relief aid in local markets, and some even employed their Malawian relatives and affines to work in their gardens, paying them in money or relief maize flour.

Considerably worse was the situation of those refugees who had arrived from the interior of Angónia District. They lacked access to land and, in many cases, had no social relations with other refugees or locals. Relief aid, moreover, provided the monotonous relish of beans and groundnuts. Such refugees endured severe lack of cash and often seized any opportunity for paid work that arose.

The terms of their *ganyu* arrangements were strikingly different from those described above. These refugees were often employed to perform the most arduous and menial tasks, such as clearing a garden before a new season. They often worked alone, without the owners of the land, and they

¹³ Caution is in order, however. 'Alienation' properly belongs to a critical tradition internal to capitalism itself and thereby presumes some of its key distinctions. One is the idea that products are the property of their producers and that, under capitalism, workers are 'alienated' from their intrinsic right to their products (see Strathern, 1988: 142, 152). My analysis, on the other hand, has shown how Dedza villagers view their access to land and its products as an outcome of social relations. Here 'alienation' prevents the person from participating in the making of composite selves.

were denied the opportunity of planting their own crops when the work was over. Their work schedules, moreover, were considerably harsher than those which relatives usually had. Whereas the latter typically worked only half a day, spending the other half in their own gardens, refugees were expected to work full days for a strictly limited period. Yet their pay for a full day was often the same as relatives' pay for half a day.

Although many refugees noted this discrepancy in payment, their most common complaint was the lack of proper access to land. Idleness troubled refugees without land; working the land clearly contributed to more than just material welfare. By refusing to let refugees participate in the full agricultural cycle local Malawians showed that no relationship existed. They did not employ refugees to perform *ganyu* labour in order to disclose constitutive relationships—there was no relationship that needed to be made visible. Yet even these observations do not provide evidence for labour contracts between abstract individuals. Some refugees were strangers, and hence open to exploitation, because they were thought to have land and kinsfolk *elsewhere*, not because they were outside social relations altogether.

There were also cases where the quality of the relations between refugees and their local hosts were transformed from strangerhood to solicitude. On the other hand, the recruitment of strangers for agricultural *ganyu* often entailed more conflict in the micro-politics of everyday life mentioned above. These intricacies of displacement in Dedza District should not, however, obscure the exceptional conditions it created for exploitative agricultural labour. Perhaps only during the Ngoni migrations in the late nineteenth century has the area witnessed a comparable influx of strangers (see Linden, 1972). But those strangers were conquerors, not disenfranchised refugees. Exploitation, prompted by the conditions of the 1986–93 displacement, underlines the historicity of the composite self as a moral sentiment.¹⁴

The turn to *madimba* cultivation as a source of income represents another unprecedented change in southern Dedza District. Never before has cash income derived so exclusively from local agriculture. In so far as *madimba* cultivation tends to be associated with men rather than women, it can, of course, also represent a major social change. Gender relations may be undergoing change simply because of new pressures on agricultural labour time—as an important source of cash, vegetable cultivation demands more time than before.

Yet the possibility of change is diluted by the fact that men's involvement in *madimba* cultivation is consistent with their earlier role as labour migrants. At both historical moments, men have been the principal providers of cash. A more crucial source of potential change is the pattern of land acquisition. If men tend to let their own sons, rather than their sisters'

¹⁴ The historiography of the Nguni peoples, including the Ngoni, has frequently demonstrated that their expansion in the late nineteenth century depended on the incorporation of slaves (see e.g. Barnes, 1954; Omer-Cooper, 1966; Vail, 1981; Kuper, 1993). Although some of these peoples also participated in the transnational slave trade, incorporation was a qualitatively different phenomenon from slave raiding for external markets.

children, have access to *madimba* gardens, this 'patrilateral inheritance' would seem to consolidate men's hold on this source of cash.

The evidence of change is, again, ambiguous. In localised marriages both spouses have long been allocated land by their matrilineal kin. In effect, the prospect of 'patrilateral inheritance' may arise from a flawed notion of matrilineages.¹⁵ As mentioned, access to land is less a matter of 'control' than of reproduction. The importance of sibling ties, and the contribution of cross-sex relations to the making of every person, mean that women wield no specific control over land in 'matrilineal systems'. In this regard, the trajectory of men's increasing involvement in *madimba* cultivation is an index of social change for a perspective which situates men and women in disparate, yet internally coherent, value systems; the gain of one sex can only appear as another's loss.¹⁶ The evidence presented here draws attention to alienation as a key historical condition of social change.

CONCLUSION

The purpose of this study has been less to discuss how much agrarian change has occurred in southern Dedza District—'small change' as opposed to 'big change'—than to sensitise us to different *kinds* of change. It would be a hasty conclusion to infer determinate changes of personhood and sociality from the most conspicuous change—the deepening impoverishment of Dedza villagers. It is beyond the scope of this article to speculate on how a different political economy, promoting the privatisation of land and sharp inequalities in villagers' access to capital and markets, would transform the circumstances.¹⁷

A sense of variable temporalities and contexts has been indispensable for understanding three features of Dedza's agrarian change: the use of small-scale labour arrangements in agriculture, the exploitation of strangers, and gender relations in the increasing reliance on *madimba* cultivation. Spurious assumptions about generalised 'commodification' could accompany the study of all these three phenomena. Persons would appear as individuals, monetary transactions revealing the extent to which their intrinsic rights have been honoured or neglected.

My evidence, both ethnographic and historical, demands subtler perspectives on personhood and sociality in the study of agrarian change. Analysis should not conceal what Dedza villagers specifically try to reveal—how the very being of particularities presupposes relationships.

¹⁵ If this notion is problematic in the study of communities that were once seen as prototypically 'matrilineal', such as Yao villages (see Verdon, 1995), it is all the more problematic in a context of extensive Ngoni influence (cf. Barnes, 1954; Linden, 1972; Phiri, 1983).

¹⁶ On gender dynamics in 'matrilineal systems' see Poewe (1981).

¹⁷ Scholars of a different theoretical persuasion would emphasise the role of religion in agrarian change. Long (1968), for example, identified Jehovah's Witnesses' ethic with social and economic innovation. However, he also observed the continuing importance of kinship and friendship with persons who did not belong to the sect (e.g. Long, 1968: 217). Such observations caution against simple 'material' and 'ideological' reasons for agrarian change.

Among Dedza villagers, persons and households are inextricably enmeshed in relationships; their dilemma is not to find 'extra-domestic' assistance by the cheapest possible means but to disclose their constitutive relationships. This dilemma of the composite self belongs to the *longue durée* of the 'local' economy. The burden of this study has been to show, nevertheless, how the composite self belongs to specific historical conditions, not to a timeless 'culture'. In understanding those conditions the shifts between livelihoods and sources of income appear ephemeral.

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ABSTRACT

This article examines agricultural labour contracts and household-based production in Dedza District, Malawi. Deepening impoverishment seemingly creates conditions for profound social changes. In agriculture, small-scale contracts rather than big work parties mobilise the bulk of 'extra-domestic' labour. Although labourers are paid in cash or in kind, they are most often the recruiter's relatives or affines. The pattern fits, therefore, uneasily with the ideas of labour as a commodity and persons as mutually independent individuals. Claims about changing values must be accompanied by careful analyses of personhood. Among Dedza villagers the notion of the self in the idioms of morality discloses social relations as the origins of a person's interests. By recruiting labour, wealthy villagers make their valued relationships visible. These observations caution against viewing 'agrarian change' as a uniform and teleological process in which the buying and selling of labour necessarily entail individualism. As an example of how, in any case, moral sentiments are historical phenomena the article examines the predicament of landless refugees in Dedza District. Under conditions of social and material alienation, agricultural labour contracts became exploitation.

RÉSUMÉ

Cet article examine les contrats de main-d'œuvre agricole et la production des ménages dans le District de Dedza, au Malawi. En apparence, l'appauvrissement croissant crée des conditions propices à de profonds changements sociaux. Dans l'agriculture, ce sont les contrats à petite échelle, et non les grandes équipes de travail, qui mobilisent la masse de la main-d'œuvre "extradomestique". Bien qu'ils soient payés en numéraire ou en nature, les ouvriers ont le plus souvent une parenté directe ou par alliance avec le recruteur. Ce modèle ne correspond donc pas bien à l'idée selon laquelle, d'une part, la main-d'œuvre est une marchandise et, d'autre part, que les individus ne sont pas interdépendants. Toute affirmation concernant les changements de valeurs doit s'accompagner d'une analyse précise de la personne. Parmi les villageois du District de Dedza, la notion du soi dans les idiomes de moralité révèle que les rapports sociaux sont à l'origine des intérêts de l'individu. En recrutant de la main-d'œuvre, les riches villageois laissent transparaître les rapports qu'ils privilégient. Ces observations mettent en garde contre l'opinion selon laquelle la "réforme agraire" est un processus uniforme et téléologique dans lequel l'achat et la vente de main-d'œuvre impliquent nécessairement l'individualisme. Pour illustrer comment, dans de nombreux cas, les sentiments moraux constituent des phénomènes historiques, l'article étudie la situation difficile des réfugiés sans terres du District de Dedza. Sur fond d'exclusion matérielle et sociale, les contrats de main-d'œuvre agricole sont devenus une forme d'exploitation.